changes her diet. As Alia began therapy "to take care" of her mind, she discovered that she fussed a lot over her weight. "It crosses a line when you start becoming unkind to yourself," she says. "The struggle is there, you just learn how to deal with it better." She is also partial to online retail therapy.

Alia has a small but tight circle of friends. They include her sister and a gang of five who studied with her at the Jamnabai Narsee school, including actor Akanksha Ranjan Kapoor. She is also known to suddenly break into "profound things" or quotes, a trait Johar believes she has inherited from her father.

When film shoots were stalled during the lockdown, Alia signed up for a course online in scriptwriting, took guitar lessons virtually, did a three-day meditation course and diligently completed a workout challenge. She also did up the apartment she now occupies in Pali Hill, in the same building as Ranbir, her whole house a reflection of the comfort the couple enjoys in their relationship. On one wall is an FC Barcelona jersey inscribed with the initials 'RK'. Another shelf has a picture of a nine-year-old Alia, dressed in a sari, resting her head on Ranbir's shoulders. The photo is from the look test of a film Bhansali was to direct but which didn't materialise. Black-and-white photographs of her and Ranbir's family, her friends, and Edward, her five-year-old Persian cat, liven up her lounge.

Alia is most animated and at ease when talking of Ranbir. "He is way calmer than I am, so I rely a lot on him to pass on some of that calmness," she says. "In our relationship, he's the cat, I am the dog. Now you go figure. Sometimes I wake up in the morning with so much energy and Ranbir is like 'Easy, easy, calm down, breathe.' If there's been an exciting day, he's the one I'll start re-enacting it to."

Much like Ranbir, Alia too had veered towards dramatics and sports in school because she had no interest in studies. "[I'd do] anything that didn't require me to look at a book and could get me out of the classroom," she says.

Both have parents who worked in the film industry, and are known to be disciplined actors. Few know the two better than their friend Ayan Mukerji, writer-director of *Wake Up Sid!*, *Yeh Jawani Hai Deewani* and the upcoming *Brahmastra*, which will be Ranbir and Alia's first film together. "Both are very gifted and committed but don't take themselves too seriously," he says. "They see themselves as regular people giving their best at work."



"She has what I call the cocktail of gunpowder and stardust that is making her blossom"

MAHESH BHATT
Father



"She is an actress-star. Alia is getting all the love and credibility fundamentally on the basis of being an actor. It's wonderful to see that somebody is loved because of what she does on screen and not for who she is"

ABHISHEK CHAUBEY
Director, Ishqiya *and* Udta Punjab

RISING STAR

Having tasted the success and the adulation, Alia has already moved on. Between patch work for *Brahmastra* and dance rehearsals for *Rocky aur Rani Ki Prem Kahani*, she says she hasn't had a chance to see *RRR* yet. Just about a decade into her career, Alia is keen to strike a balance between the personal and the professional. Like her peers Deepika, Anushka Sharma and Priyanka Chopra, she too has started a production company, Eternal Sunshine. Shaheen is a key member of its creative team. Its first project, *Darlings*, will be her next release, followed by *Brahmastra*. Hollywood is beckoning too; she soon heads to London to shoot her debut, *Heart of Stone*, a spy thriller produced by Netflix.

In what's promising to shape up as a pivotal year, rumours are rife that Alia and Ranbir will finally tie the knot. Had it not been for the pandemic, Ranbir says they would have already been married. Alia is more circumspect in her response: "I am just taking each day as it comes and making the most of it every day. I am just going with feeling." Going with feeling is also what she does best in front of the camera. That is why the crew on the sets of *Gangubai...* called her 'Bachchan', the legend with whom she shares her initials. As Alia received yet another bouquet and note from Big B, Mahesh Bhatt found himself wondering if his youngest would burn out soon. Bachchan assured him, saying she wouldn't because "she doesn't know how she does it". But maybe Alia has known it all along. Maybe she is just putting on an act. But we are all falling for it. ■